

Chubby Frog / Asian Painted Frog (*Kaloula pulchra*)

Difficulty: Easy to Intermediate

Chubby frogs, also called Asian painted frogs, banded bullfrogs, or Asian painted bullfrogs, are stout narrow-mouthed frogs that typically reach about 2-3 inches (5-8 cm). Females are usually larger than males. They are famous for their round body, cream-to-orange side stripes, defensive “puffing up,” and sticky skin secretions.

Kaloula pulchra is widespread across South and Southeast Asia and has also been introduced to several islands. It is an adaptable nocturnal, fossorial species found around forest edges, wetlands, agricultural land, and urban areas. In the wild it spends much of its time under leaf litter or buried in loose soil, emerging especially during warm rains to feed and breed in still or temporary pools.

Long-term captive longevity data are limited, but well-kept chubby frogs commonly live for many years. Good care should focus less on keeping the air “swampy” and more on providing deep diggable substrate, a moisture gradient, clean water, modest temperatures, varied small prey, and very little handling.

Shopping List

- 24" x 18" x 12" or larger front-opening terrestrial enclosure for one or two similarly sized adults; larger is always welcome
- Secure ventilated lid - chubby frogs can climb surprisingly well when searching for shelter
- Low-output linear UVB fixture suitable for a shaded/nocturnal amphibian setup; optional but recommended when a true gradient can be provided
- Low-wattage white overhead heat source on a dimming thermostat only if room temperatures are too cool
- Plug-in timer and a low-heat daylight or plant LED for a consistent day/night cycle
- Digital probe thermometer/hygrometer; infrared thermometer useful for checking surface temperatures
- 5-6" or more of soft, pesticide- and fertilizer-free soil-based substrate suitable for burrowing
- Clean leaf litter plus cork flats, low hides, sturdy plants, and visual cover
- Shallow, easy-exit water dish large enough for the frog to sit in comfortably without swimming
- Amphibian-safe water conditioner that neutralizes chlorine and chloramine
- Varied small live feeders such as appropriately sized crickets, roaches, black soldier fly larvae, small earthworms, and other cultured invertebrates
- Amphibian/reptile calcium supplement and a balanced multivitamin containing a usable source of vitamin A
- Powder-free nitrile gloves or a clean damp transfer cup for necessary moves
- Digital gram scale for routine weight and body-condition checks

Housing

Chubby frogs are terrestrial and strongly burrowing, so floor space and substrate depth matter more than height. Red Rocks recommends at least a 24" x 18" footprint for one or two similarly sized adults. Smaller enclosures can work temporarily for juveniles or quarantine, but a larger permanent enclosure makes it much easier to create dry-to-moist and cool-to-warm gradients.

Provide at least 5-6" of diggable substrate across most of the enclosure. A zoo husbandry guide for microhylid frogs recommends at least 150 mm (about 6") for *Kaloula*, reflecting how central digging is to normal behavior. Add a generous layer of leaf litter, at least two low hides, and sturdy live or artificial plants. These frogs often stay buried for long periods; that is normal behavior, not a sign that the enclosure is “too large.”

A secure lid is essential. Although they are fossorial, *Kaloula* can climb when seeking shelter and may wedge into surprisingly small gaps.

Lighting & UVB

Provide a consistent 10-12 hour day/night cycle with complete darkness at night. Chubby frogs are nocturnal and should always have deep shade and covered retreats. Do not use red, blue, purple, or “moonlight” bulbs overnight.

Species-specific UVB trials in *K. pulchra* are lacking. However, professional amphibian husbandry literature supports providing a UV gradient rather than assuming nocturnal frogs receive no UV at all. Our conservative recommendation is low-level Ferguson Zone 1-style exposure: roughly UVI 0.5-1.0 at the most exposed usable surface, falling to near zero under leaf litter and hides. UVB should cover only part of the enclosure, never the whole floor.

If UVB is not provided, vitamin D3 must be supplied through an appropriate supplement plan. If UVB is provided, measure actual exposure when possible because mesh and distance can greatly reduce output.

Heating

Chubby frogs generally do best at modest temperatures. A practical target is about 72-78°F through most of the enclosure during the day, with a small optional warm area around 80-82°F if the frog can easily retreat to cooler, damp substrate. Night temperatures around 68-72°F are appropriate for healthy adults.

Most homes do not need supplemental heat year-round. If heat is needed, use a low-wattage white overhead source controlled by a thermostat and place it over only one side. Do not use a heat mat underneath the enclosure: these frogs burrow to escape heat, so bottom heat can turn their refuge into the hottest and driest part of the habitat.

Avoid prolonged enclosure temperatures in the mid-80s or higher. Amphibians can overheat quickly and often show few obvious warning signs until they are already in trouble.

Humidity

Do not chase one constantly high humidity number. Aim for roughly 60-80% relative humidity with normal daily fluctuations, while maintaining a moisture gradient in the substrate. One side can be kept noticeably moist and cool while another is allowed to become slightly drier near the surface. The lower substrate should never become bone-dry.

The substrate should feel like damp forest soil - able to hold shape when gently squeezed, but not dripping or muddy. Persistent condensation, waterlogged soil, sour odor, fungus blooms, or stagnant air usually mean the enclosure is too wet or under-ventilated.

Water

Provide a shallow water dish at all times, large enough for the frog to sit in with its body supported and head comfortably above water. Chubby frogs are not aquatic pets and should not be forced to swim. Use a dish with an easy exit, and add a smooth stone or gentle ramp if needed.

Use dechlorinated tap water or another amphibian-safe mineral-containing water. Municipal chloramine does not reliably disappear by letting water sit; use a conditioner that specifically treats chlorine and chloramine. Do not use distilled water as the routine soaking or drinking water. Change the dish daily and immediately whenever the frog soils it.

Substrate

Deep substrate is a welfare requirement for this species, not just a humidity tool. Use 5-6" or more of pesticide- and fertilizer-free soil-based material that stays soft enough to burrow into. A practical mix is organic topsoil with coco fiber and a modest amount of washed play sand; bioactive mixes also work well when drainage is adequate.

Top the surface with clean hardwood leaf litter. Avoid cedar, pine, aromatic mulches, sharp gravel, calcium sand, reptile carpet, and loose long-fiber sphagnum as the main feeding surface. Paper towel is useful for quarantine or medical observation but does not allow normal burrowing and should not be the permanent substrate for a healthy adult.

Food

Chubby frogs are insectivores with a strong natural bias toward small invertebrates. Field diet studies repeatedly find ants and termites among the most frequently consumed prey, along with beetles, cockroaches, and other arthropods. In captivity, do not try to recreate that diet with wild ants or termites; they may bite, sting, carry pesticides, or introduce parasites.

Use a varied rotation of cultured feeders such as crickets, small roaches, black soldier fly larvae, small earthworms/nightcrawlers, silkworms, and appropriately sized mealworms. Prey should generally be no wider than the distance between the frog's eyes. Gut-load feeder insects for 24-48 hours when appropriate.

Juveniles: small meals daily or every other day while growing. Adults: a moderate meal about every 3-5 days is a reasonable starting point, adjusted to body condition, season, and activity. Feed mainly in the evening. Do not power-feed simply because the frog accepts food; obesity is a disease in amphibians and can be difficult to recognize in an already round species.

Supplements

Captive feeder insects are not nutritionally complete by themselves. Use calcium consistently and a reputable multivitamin on a planned rotation rather than stacking several products at once. A supplement containing usable preformed vitamin A is important because amphibians can develop hypovitaminosis A and "short tongue syndrome" on deficient diets.

If measured low-level UVB is provided, plain calcium without D3 should usually be the default calcium product, with D3 supplied only according to the chosen supplement program. Without UVB, dietary D3 becomes more important. Follow product directions and avoid heavy dusting.

Decor & Enrichment

Enrichment for a fossorial frog is mostly about choice. Deep soil, leaf litter, multiple covered retreats, plants, cork, moisture gradients, and varied prey allow normal digging, hiding, foraging, and seasonal behavior. Leave some open feeding space but avoid a bare enclosure.

Because these frogs can climb better than their shape suggests, low sturdy branches, cork tubes, or broad plant leaves can be offered, but avoid tall hard structures that create a fall risk.

Cleaning & Maintenance

Inspect the frog and enclosure daily even if the animal is buried. Remove feces, shed, dead feeders, and spoiled food promptly. Rinse and refill the water dish every day. In a non-bioactive enclosure, replace soiled substrate as needed rather than waiting for a rigid calendar date. In a bioactive setup, the cleanup crew helps with waste but does not replace observation, spot cleaning, or water-dish hygiene.

New frogs should be quarantined before sharing tools, substrate, or drainage water with established amphibians. Because amphibian disease can spread through wet equipment, keep transfer cups, feeding tools, and cleaning supplies separate during quarantine.

Cohabitation

Chubby frogs are not social animals, but similarly sized individuals can sometimes be maintained together when the enclosure is spacious and resources are duplicated. For two adults, use at least the recommended 24" x 18" footprint, multiple hides, deep substrate, and more than one feeding area. Watch closely for weight loss, persistent hiding, bite injuries, food competition, or one frog consistently occupying the best refuge.

Single housing remains the simplest option for monitoring appetite, feces, weight, and health. Never mix chubby frogs with other amphibian species, and never place a much smaller frog with a larger animal that could attempt to swallow it.

Breeding & Seasonality

In the wild, *K. pulchra* is an explosive breeder associated with warm rains and still or temporary pools. Captive breeding is possible but requires a purpose-built rain chamber, careful water-quality

management, and experience rearing large numbers of tiny tadpoles and metamorphs. A pet enclosure should not be flooded or deliberately subjected to extreme “dry seasons” simply to imitate monsoon cycling.

Common Health Concerns

- Obesity: this species is naturally round, so use weight trends and body condition rather than appetite alone to decide how much to feed.
- Metabolic bone disease: inadequate calcium, vitamin D3, UVB strategy, or overall nutrition can cause weakness, tremors, abnormal posture, and skeletal deformity.
- Vitamin A deficiency: poor prey capture, tongue dysfunction, weight loss, eye or mouth changes, and lethargy can occur when diets lack usable vitamin A.
- Dehydration or inappropriate moisture: dry, tacky skin and persistent hiding can indicate dehydration, while chronically wet conditions increase skin and bacterial disease risk.
- Skin disease / “red leg” signs: redness, ulcers, unusual shedding, swelling, foul odor, or severe lethargy warrant prompt veterinary attention.
- Parasites and infectious disease: risk is higher in newly acquired or unknown-origin amphibians.

Fecal testing and strict quarantine are valuable, especially before introducing animals to an established collection.

Seek an amphibian-experienced veterinarian promptly for persistent refusal to eat, rapid weight loss, inability to right itself, labored breathing, prolapse, seizures/tremors, severe bloating, open wounds, or abnormal skin color that does not resolve.

Hot Tip: Handling

Chubby frogs are display animals. Routine handling provides no benefit and can damage their highly permeable skin. They may also secrete a sticky defensive mucus when frightened, which can irritate eyes and mucous membranes.

For necessary moves, wear clean powder-free nitrile gloves rinsed with amphibian-safe water or guide the frog into a clean damp transfer cup. Support the whole body, keep handling brief, and never use lotion, sanitizer, soap residue, nicotine, or household cleaners near the frog.

Care Standards Note

This guide is intentionally conservative and welfare-forward. Where species-specific captive studies are limited, recommendations are based on published *K. pulchra* natural history, professional zoo/amphibian husbandry guidance, veterinary amphibian medicine, and current UV-lighting principles. Individual animals may require adjustments based on age, body condition, source, season, and veterinarian guidance.

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